SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #43 · MENTAL HEALTH AND SEEKING HELP

"If I just prayed more, I wouldn't feel this way."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Well-meaning people may say, "Just pray about it," or "Give it to God," leaving the suffering person feeling guilty. They pray more, feel no relief, and conclude that something is wrong with them or with their faith.

What Scripture teaches

Elijah, discouraged, prayed that he might die, and God did not rebuke him. He sent an angel who said, "Get up and eat," and let him sleep. Paul prayed three times about his thorn, and God answered, "My grace is sufficient for you." David prayed often and still wrote, "Why are you downcast, O my soul?" Prayer is vital, and it often brings peace. But God also gives rest, food, friends, doctors, and counselors. Continued pain is not proof of insufficient prayer.

> *"While he himself traveled on a day's journey into the wilderness. He sat down under a broom tree and prayed that he might die. 'I have had enough, LORD,' he said. 'Take my life, for I am no better than my fathers.' Then he lay down under the broom tree and fell asleep. Suddenly an angel touched him and said, 'Get up and eat.'"* (1 Kings 19:4–5).

Also see

> "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me. That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong" (2 Corinthians 12:9–10).

> "Why are you downcast, O my soul? Why the unease within me? Put your hope in God, for I will yet praise Him for the salvation of His presence" (Psalm 42:5).

> "Be anxious for nothing, but in everything, by prayer and petition, with thanksgiving, present your requests to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus" (Philippians 4:6–7).

> "When anxiety overwhelms me, Your consolation delights my soul" (Psalm 94:19).

Common self-statements

- If I had more faith, I would feel better.
- My prayers must not be good enough.
- Something is wrong with my relationship with God.
- I should not feel this way.
- God is withholding relief.
- I need to pray harder.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing prayer either removes feelings completely or has failed.
- Mind reading: Assuming God is displeased.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling unrelieved and concluding that I prayed wrongly.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that nothing will help.

Challenging questions

- Who told me that prayer should remove these feelings?
- How did God care for Elijah when he was despairing?
- What other help might God have provided for me?
- What do I need besides prayer, such as rest, food, friends, or counsel?
- What did David do with feelings that persisted?
- What is one practical step I can add to prayer?

Truth summary

> Prayer matters, and so do rest, food, friends, and professional help. Persisting feelings do not prove failed faith. I can pray honestly and also care for myself and seek help.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Prayer, How to
- Depression, Symptoms of
- Tired
- Faith
- Suffering

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Divorce
- Forgive/Forgiveness

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I just prayed more, I wouldn't feel this way"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I just prayed more, I wouldn't feel this way." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who said this?
- ☐ How did God care for Elijah?
- ☐ What other help might He give?
- ☐ What do I need besides prayer?
- ☐ What did David do?
- ☐ What can I add?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God cared for Elijah with rest and food.
- ☐ His grace is sufficient for me.
- ☐ David prayed and still felt downcast.
- ☐ Prayer and practical help work together.
- ☐ Feelings that persist are not proof of failed faith.
- ☐ I can ask for help.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

☐ 1 Kings 19:4–5

"While he himself traveled on a day's journey into the wilderness. He sat down under a broom tree and prayed that he might die. 'I have had enough, LORD,' he said. 'Take my life, for I am no better than my fathers.' Then he lay down under the broom tree and fell asleep. Suddenly an angel touched him and said, 'Get up and eat.'"

☐ 2 Corinthians 12:9–10

"But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me. That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong."

☐ Psalm 42:5

"Why are you downcast, O my soul? Why the unease within me? Put your hope in God, for I will yet praise Him for the salvation of His presence."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Prayer and care: Each week, note one prayer and one practical step of care.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 1 Kings 19:4–5 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God cared for Elijah with rest and food, and He cares for me.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Depression, Symptoms of" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Pray honestly. Tell God exactly how you feel.
- [ ] Meet basic needs. Sleep, eat, and move.
- [ ] Reach out. Tell a friend or counselor.
- [ ] Read 1 Kings 19. Notice how God cared for Elijah.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I just prayed more, I wouldn't feel this way": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Prayer and care
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I just prayed more, I wouldn't feel this way.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I am weary and still struggling. Thank You for caring for me as You did Elijah. Help me pray honestly and receive the help You provide. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.